

BYZANTINE JEWELS

Just like the Romans had done before them, the people of the Byzantine empire wore jewellery for decoration and to indicate status, and gave it as diplomatic gifts.

Between the 4th and 15th centuries, the huge wealth of the empire and its expanded trading network meant that Byzantine jewellers had unprecedented access to vast quantities of gold and a variety of gemstones, especially pearls and garnets. As a consequence, the Byzantine era is noted for its abundance of lavish jewellery.

Byzantine jewellery often featured polished cabochons prominently set in gold. Showy, colourful pieces were the most popular, and rings, bracelets, and necklaces often featured stones in alternating colours. The empire's extensive gold mines supplied the jewellers, and the metal was intricately worked into detailed open patterns known as *opus intarsiale*, always with the intention of showing off the brightly-coloured stones. Religion played an important role in jewellery design: crucifix neck pendants, earrings, and rings engraved with images of Christ, angels, and the saints were thought to provide spiritual protection and express devotion, as well as displaying the wearer's wealth.

[They wore] collars of gold and translucent necklaces of sparkling gems and precious pearls

Niketas **Choniates**

Greek Byzantine civil servant

Empress Theodora, Byzantine mosaic, San Vitale, Ravenna, c.6th century

This mosaic depicts the Empress and her attendants adorned with gems. She wears a diadem studded with sapphires, emeralds, and red stones, strands of pearls, and a square pendant set with emeralds, pearls, and sapphires.

